

Reason, Revelation and Faith

Philosophy Optional · Paper II · Philosophy of Religion

COMPLETE MULTI-PAGE FLOWCHART COMPANION

Translation-audited edition: every Sanskrit, Pali, Prakrit or Hindi technical term carries an immediate English meaning at first use in every visual box.

Regenerated 2026-08-21 · Landscape continuation format

MASTER LEARNING SEQUENCE

1. Separate reason, revelation and faith
2. Compare rationalism, fideism, harmony and two-source models
3. Distinguish propositional from non-propositional revelation
4. Explain Aquinas' intellectual assent and Kierkegaard's leap
5. Distinguish faith from belief and map Indian śraddhā (faithful trust)
6. Use Barbour's science–religion models
7. Evaluate Hume on miracles and testimony
8. Compare evidentialism with proper basicity
9. Apply Indian pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) parity
10. Convert doctrine into 10/15/20-mark answers

TRANSLATION AND DEFINITION RULE

Every visual box is independently readable: its first Sanskrit, Pali, Prakrit or Hindi technical term is followed immediately by an exam-safe English meaning. Long definitions wrap and continue; no fixed line limit is used.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

Source-complete coverage ledger and answer-worthiness labels

[FACT] identifies retained repository doctrine or verified question data. [INFERENCE] identifies learner-facing organisation or judgement.

Source corpus	Final location	Retention decision
Canonical owner §§0–7	Basic Learning Session	Full map, doctrines, parity bench, drills and answer skeletons retained
Canonical owner §§9–19	Optional Advanced	Full advanced doctrine, debates, criticisms, traps, routing, directive control and source discipline retained after practice
Audited Philosophy of Religion PYQ ledger	PYQs and Answer Practice	All 11 owner questions from 2019–2025 retained with exact wording and new full solutions
New premium diagnostics	MCQs / Remediation	40 core and eight remedial questions cover every major distinction with strict rotation
New original practice	PYQs and Answer Practice	Six solved, non-PYQ models retained at 10/15/20-mark levels
Philosophy of Religion advanced dossier	Optional Advanced	Proper basicity, testimony, doxastic voluntarism and Indian śabda (verbal testimony) refinements reconciled
Consolidated register	Final section	A–L retrieval framework retains the complete answer logic without repeating full prose

Visible learning labels. Reason's role, revelation models, Aquinas, Kierkegaard, faith–belief, science–religion, miracles, evidentialism and Indian parity are CORE PAPER II. Directive decoding, premise control, objections and graded verdicts are CORE ANSWER. Contemporary examples and cross-topic links are SUPPORTING. Full warrant machinery, specialist testimony theory and second-order doxastic debates are OPTIONAL ADVANCED.

What not to over-study. Do not import the entire analytic epistemology of warrant into a short answer, narrate Galileo instead of using models, or collect miracle stories. Master each distinction, its named advocate, one objection/reply and the exact examiner demand.

Learning roadmap

Unit	Learner objective
1	Separate reason, revelation and faith
2	Compare rationalism, fideism, harmony and two-source models
3	Distinguish propositional from non-propositional revelation
4	Explain Aquinas' intellectual assent and Kierkegaard's leap
5	Distinguish faith from belief and map Indian śraddhā (faithful trust)
6	Use Barbour's science–religion models
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Current scholarly anchor — [SUPPORTING]

[FACT] Fact: Religion News Service reported on 26 May 2026 that a consortium involving Brigham Young, Baylor, Notre Dame and Yeshiva researchers tested fourteen AI models for multi-faith bias and presented findings at an AI ethics summit in Athens.
[CAUTION] Inference: The episode gives a contemporary use for the 2020 science–technology PYQ: technical systems can classify and reproduce religious perspectives, but questions of moral authority, fairness and human dignity remain philosophical and normative. It does not establish any theological claim.

Visual gateway — the three functions

REASON asks: Is the claim coherent and warranted?
|
REVELATION claims: A truth or divine presence is disclosed.
|
FAITH asks: Will the disclosure be trusted and lived?

Failure modes:
reason alone -> reductionism
revelation alone -> unauthenticated authority
faith alone -> arbitrariness or fanaticism

Master verdict: Reason should be regulative but need not be constitutive. Revelation supplies alleged content unavailable to unaided reason; faith receives and commits to it. Each needs the corrective pressure of the others.

0. ONE-SCREEN MAP [CAUTION]

REASON <---- how do they relate? ----> FAITH
(proof, (trust, commitment,
argument, assent to what is not proved)
natural theology) |
| REVELATION (God's self-disclosure)
| +--- Propositional (truths revealed) --+
FOUR STANCES: +---- Non-propositional (God's acts/ +
1. Reason > Faith (rationalism) encounter; Hick)
2. Faith > Reason (fideism — Kierkegaard's LEAP)
3. Faith seeking understanding (Augustine/Anselm — harmony)
4. Reason & Revelation as two paths (Aquinas — natural + revealed theology)

[MEMORY] Mnemonic — "RRF: Reason argues, Revelation discloses, Faith trusts." The four stances range from reason-first (rationalism) to faith-first (fideism), with Aquinas' two-storey harmony in between.

1. REASON IN RELIGION [FACT]

* Role (2024 PYQ): reason (a) constructs natural theology (proofs for God), (b) tests coherence of doctrines, (c) interprets scripture, (d) defends faith (apologetics). [FACT]
Rationalism: religious beliefs must meet the bar of reason/evidence (Clifford: "it is wrong always... to believe anything upon insufficient evidence"*). [FACT]
* Limits: proofs are inconclusive (see Proofs note); the transcendent may exceed reason -> space for revelation & faith. [CAUTION]
* Rational vs irrational aspects of faith (2023): faith has a rational side (grounds, coherence, cumulative evidence) and a supra-/non-rational side (trust, commitment, the leap beyond proof). [CAUTION]

2. REVELATION [FACT]

* Definition: God's self-disclosure to humanity — the source of knowledge unavailable to unaided reason.
* Two models (2025 PYQ): [FACT]
Propositional view: revelation delivers truths/propositions (doctrines) to be believed — grounds revealed theology (Trinity, incarnation), distinct from natural theology (what reason alone discovers, e.g. God's existence). Natural vs Revealed Theology.*
Non-propositional view (Hick): revelation is God's acts/self-presence in history & experience, humanly interpreted* — not a set of dictated propositions.
* Epistemic justification of revelation (2024 PYQ): how do we validate a revelation-claim? — internal coherence, moral fruits, the religious experience of the recipient, communal testimony, congruence with reason. Problem: competing revelations across religions; circularity (using the revelation to validate itself). [CAUTION]

3. FAITH [FACT]

* Definition: faith = trust in and commitment to God/the transcendent, involving assent that goes beyond conclusive proof (but not necessarily against reason).
Aquinas — faith as "intellectual assent" (2025 PYQ): faith is an act of the intellect assenting to revealed truth, commanded by the will (moved by grace). It is a mean between knowledge (which has proof/sight) and opinion* (which has fear of error): faith has the firmness of knowledge without the vision. This reconciles reason & faith — reason establishes the "preambles" (God exists), faith accepts the "mysteries" (Trinity) that exceed but don't contradict reason. [FACT]
* Kierkegaard — faith as the LEAP: faith is a passionate, subjective commitment in "objective uncertainty"; the leap of faith transcends reason (Abraham's "teleological suspension of the ethical"). Fideism — faith needs no rational proof and may even require its "crucifixion". [FACT]
Faith indispensable for revelation? (2022 PYQ): revelation must be received — it becomes revelation for someone* only through the faith that recognises & accepts it; without faith, an event is just an event. So faith is a precondition of revelation's efficacy (Hick's "experiencing-as"). [CAUTION]

4. THE FOUR STANCES — comparison [CAUTION]

Stance	Relation	Thinker	One-line
Rationalism	reason judges faith	Clifford, Locke	believe only on evidence
Fideism	faith over/against reason	Kierkegaard, Tertullian	the leap; "credo quia absurdum"
Faith seeking understanding	harmony, faith first	Augustine, Anselm	"credo ut intelligam"
Two-source harmony	reason + revelation, distinct domains	Aquinas	natural + revealed theology

[MEMORY] Aquinas is the balanced default: reason & revelation cannot conflict (both from God); reason proves the preambles, revelation supplies the mysteries; faith is intellectual assent under grace. Deploy this for any "reconcile reason & faith" question.

5. FOUNDATIONAL STATEMENT BANK [CAUTION]

- [FACT] The Augustinian–Anselmian formula *credo ut intelligam* presents faith as seeking understanding.
- [FACT] Aquinas places faith between demonstrative knowledge and wavering opinion: it is firm assent to what is not seen.
- [FACT] Kierkegaard links faith with passionate inward commitment under objective uncertainty.
- [FACT] Clifford's evidentialist maxim makes insufficient evidence morally relevant to belief.
- [VERIFY] The popular formula *credo quia absurdum* is commonly associated with Tertullian but is not a safe verbatim quotation from him; use it only as a later slogan for extreme fideism.

6. APPLIED-QUESTION DRILLS [CAUTION]

- [Aquinas] "How does Aquinas' faith-as-'intellectual assent' reconcile reason & faith?" (2025) -> §3.
- [Reason] "Role of reason in religion." (2024) -> §1.
- [Revelation] "Distinguish natural & revealed theology (propositional view)." (2025) -> §2.
- [Justification] "Epistemic justifications of revelation-claims." (2024) -> §2.
- [Faith-revelation] "Is faith indispensable for revelation?" (2022) -> §3.
- [Science] "Significance of religion vis-à-vis present scientific and technological development." (2020, 10m) -> §9.6 — Barbour's four models, not a Galileo narrative.
- [Faith/belief] "Basic tenets of faith; distinguish faith and belief." (2020, 15m) -> §9.7 — enumerate the seven tenets, then the five axes.
- [Justification] "Can religious beliefs be justified?" (2023, 10m) -> §9.9 — evidentialism vs Reformed epistemology; add the *svataḥ/parataḥ-prāmāṇya* (intrinsic versus externally certified validity) mapping.
- [Reason regulative] "Can reason be a regulative force in forming religious beliefs?" (2021, 20m) -> §1 + §9.1 + §9.9 — regulative ≠ constitutive; reason can veto and discipline without generating.
- [Rational/irrational] "Rational and irrational aspects of faith." (2023, 15m) -> §9.5 — insist on supra-rational as a third category.
- [Miracles] "Can testimony establish a miracle?" -> §9.8.

6A. INDIAN–WESTERN PARITY BENCH [CAUTION]

Issue	Western	Indian	Note
Is testimony an independent source of knowledge?	Locke and Hume: reducible to experience	Nyāya (logic and realist epistemology school) and Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school): śabda (verbal testimony) is an independent pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge); Cārvāka (materialist school) denies it	The Indian debate is explicitly epistemological
Is validity intrinsic or extrinsic?	Foundationalism vs Reformed proper basicality	Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school) svataḥ-prāmāṇya (intrinsic validity of cognition) vs Nyāya (logic and realist epistemology school) parataḥ-prāmāṇya (validity established through external confirmation)	The closest exact parallel in the whole clause
Whose speech is scripture?	God's word (propositional revelation)	Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school): apauruṣeya (authorless and not of human origin) — no author, human or divine	India has a form of scriptural authority with no revealer
Faith as trust	Fides qua (act of trusting faith); Tillich's ultimate concern	Śraddhā (faithful trust) (Gītā (Song of the Lord) 17.2–3); Buddhist saddhā (provisional trust directed toward verification)	Indian trust is verification-directed (Kālāma Sutta (Discourse to the Kālāmas))
Reason's role	Preambles, coherence, apologetics	Manana (reflective reasoning); tarka (hypothetical reasoning) as auxiliary, never independently probative in Vedānta (school grounded in the concluding teaching of the Vedas)	Both subordinate reason without eliminating it
Miracles as authentication	Central to Western apologetics	Siddhis (extraordinary yogic powers) declared obstacles (YS 3.37); Buddha rejects displays (Kevaddha Sutta (Discourse to Kevaddha))	India largely declines the strategy — a contrast, not a parallel



7. PYQ-MAPPED MODEL-ANSWER SKELETONS [CAUTION]

7.1 — "How does Aquinas' faith-as-intellectual-assent reconcile Reason and Faith?" (2025, 10m)

Intro : the reason–faith tension; Aquinas' harmonising solution.
Body : faith = intellect assenting to revealed truth, moved by will+grace; a MEAN between knowledge (has proof) and opinion (fears error) — firm assent without sight.
Reason proves preambles (God exists); revelation supplies mysteries; no conflict (both from God).
Assess: contrast fideism (Kierkegaard's leap) & rationalism (Clifford).
Concl : reason and faith are complementary storeys of one truth.



7.2 — "Is the notion of faith indispensable for the idea of revelation?" (2022, 10m)

Intro : revelation = God's self-disclosure; must be received to count.
Body : an event becomes revelation only when interpreted/accepted in faith (Hick's "experiencing-as"); without faith, no recognition -> no revelation "for" the person.
Crit : propositional view — truths are revealed objectively regardless of reception; but efficacy still needs faith.
Concl : faith is the indispensable subjective condition of revelation's reception.



7.3 — "Basic tenets of faith. Distinguish between faith and belief." (2020, 15m)

Intro : two obligations in the stem — the tenets, and the distinction. Do both, in that order.
Tenets: (1) an ultimate object; (2) assent to some content; (3) trust beyond available evidence; (4) commitment of will, with risk; (5) hope; (6) community/tradition; (7) fruits.
Distinction: object (proposition vs person/ultimate) | grammar (believe THAT vs believe IN) | mode (assent vs assent + entrusting) | voluntariness (belief largely involuntary; faith engages the will) | failure-mode (falsehood vs betrayal).
Support: Aquinas' fides quae (content of faith) / fides qua (act of trusting faith); W. C. Smith (Faith and Belief) on the modern narrowing of "belief"; Tillich's ultimate concern; Buber's I–Thou.
Indian: Gītā (Song of the Lord) 17.2–3 — śraddhā (faithful trust) graded sāttvika (clarity-dominated)/rājasa (passion-dominated)/tāmasa (inertia-dominated), and "as is one's śraddhā, so is one";
Buddhist saddhā (provisional trust directed toward verification) as provisional trust directed toward verification (Kālāma Sutta (Discourse to the Kālāmas)).
Crit : the reductionist objection ("believing in" = believing that X exists and is trustworthy) and the reply that this loses the performative act of entrusting.
Concl : faith is not weaker belief but a different act; they can come apart in both directions.



7.4 — "Significance of religion vis-à-vis present scientific and technological development." (2020, 10m)

Intro : the relation is a set of MODELS, not a single verdict.
Body : Barbour's four — Conflict (warfare thesis of Draper–White; now rejected by historians); Independence (Gould's NOMA; cost = both sides silenced); Dialogue (boundary questions — why a universe, why intelligible, fine-tuning; methodological parallels: models, metaphors, theory-ladenness); Integration (natural theology, theology of nature, process thought; hostage to current science).
[Haught's Conflict/Contrast/Contact/Confirmation as an alternative frame.]
Indian: Vivekananda's claim that Vedānta (school grounded in the concluding teaching of the Vedas) is experience-based and so science-compatible ("science of the soul" — report as a claim); Radhakrishnan's levels of one integral experience;
Aurobindo's evolutionary integration. Classical root: is śabda (verbal testimony) an independent pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge)?
Assess: religion's continuing significance is normative and existential — technology settles what we CAN do, not what we SHOULD, and not what a life is for.
Concl : dialogue at the boundary questions, with local conflict only where a genuinely empirical claim is made.



7.5 — "Can religious beliefs be justified?" (2023, 10m)

Intro : the question is about the STANDARD of justification, not about God's existence.
Body : Evidentialism — Locke; Clifford's ethics of belief (shipowner); Flew's presumption of atheism.
James's reply — living, forced, momentous options where evidence is inconclusive.
Reformed epistemology — Plantinga: the objection presupposes classical foundationalism, which is self-referentially incoherent and too narrow (memory, other minds); theistic belief can be PROPERLY BASIC — grounded, warranted by proper function, and defeasible.
Great Pumpkin objection and reply. Alston: doxastic practices, including sense perception, cannot be non-circularly validated.
Indian: Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school) svataḥ-prāmāṇya (intrinsic validity of cognition) ≈ proper basicality; Nyāya (logic and realist epistemology school) parataḥ-prāmāṇya (validity established through external confirmation) ≈ evidentialism;
Cārvāka (materialist school) is the strict evidentialist limit.
Concl : yes — but justification is internal to a doxastic practice, which relocates the real problem from evidential insufficiency to religious diversity.



PYQ ROUTING CHECKPOINT

PYQ 1 — 2019, Q5(a), 10 marks

PYQ 2 — 2020, Q5(a), 10 marks

PYQ 3 — 2020, Q7(c), 15 marks

PYQ 4 — 2021, Q7(a), 20 marks

PYQ 5 — 2022, Q5(d), 10 marks

PYQ 6 — 2023, Q5(b), 10 marks

PYQ 7 — 2023, Q6(c), 15 marks

PYQ 8 — 2024, Q5(d), 10 marks

PYQ 9 — 2024, Q7(b), 15 marks

PYQ 10 — 2025, Q5(e), 10 marks

PYQ 11 — 2025, Q6(c), 15 marks

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH — NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Advanced-dossier reconciliation — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

The dossier confirms that Reformed epistemology versus evidentialism is now core, while full proper-function machinery remains optional. Public testimony and private disclosure should be treated as defeasible and cumulative; doxastic voluntarism concerns indirect control through attention and practice rather than instant choice; and Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school)/Advaita (non-dual Vedānta) śabda (verbal testimony) must not be redescribed as creator-dictated scripture.



9. ADVANCED DOCTRINE DOSSIERS

9.1 Natural reason and natural theology

- * Doctrine statement. [FACT] Reason can infer and test some religious claims without relying on a special historical disclosure.
- * Argument. [FACT] It identifies publicly accessible premises, derives implications, tests coherence, and distinguishes demonstration, probability and practical postulation.
- * Presupposition. [CAUTION] Reality is intelligible and reason is not wholly corrupted or confined to empirical objects.
- * Distinction. [FACT] Natural theology differs from philosophy of religion: the former argues toward theological conclusions; the latter also analyses language, experience and warrant.
- * Canonical examples. [FACT] Aquinas' preambles of faith; Nyāya (logic and realist epistemology school) inference to Īśvara (the Lord).
- * Objection -> reply. [CAUTION] Kant restricts speculative reason beyond possible experience. Natural theologians reply that metaphysical inference concerns conditions of experience, not another observed object.



9.2 Propositional revelation

- * Doctrine statement. [FACT] Revelation communicates divinely authorised truths that unaided reason could not discover or securely know.
- * Argument. [FACT] (1) God can disclose; (2) prophets/scripture mediate disclosure; (3) signs, testimony and coherence warrant reception; (4) doctrine articulates revealed content.
- * Presupposition. [CAUTION] A personal God acts in history and reliable transmission is possible.
- * Distinction. [FACT] Inspiration concerns divine–human authorship; revelation concerns disclosure; infallibility concerns freedom from error. They are not interchangeable.
- Canonical examples. [FACT] Aquinas distinguishes truths accessible to reason from mysteries known through revelation; Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school)'s apauruṣeya (authorless and not of human origin)* Veda is authoritative but not a creator God's speech.
- * Objection -> reply. [CAUTION] Rival revelations and circular authentication weaken certainty. Replies appeal to cumulative criteria—coherence, moral fruit, testimony and transformative power—without pretending neutrality.



9.3 Non-propositional revelation and Hick

- * Doctrine statement. [FACT] Revelation is primarily divine self-disclosure in events and encounter; propositions are human interpretations of that disclosure.
- * Argument. [FACT] (1) Events are religiously ambiguous; (2) faith perceives them as divine action; (3) communities conceptualise that encounter; (4) doctrinal diversity reflects interpretive schemes.
- * Presupposition. [CAUTION] Experience is always concept-laden and divine freedom is not exhausted by statements.
- * Distinction. [FACT] An event is not automatically revelation for every observer; "revelatory event" names an experienced-as structure.
- * Canonical example. [FACT] The same historical event can be described in secular causal terms or received as providential.
- * Objection -> reply. [CAUTION] If interpretation constitutes revelation, projection threatens. Hick replies through moral-spiritual transformation and the resistance of reality to arbitrary interpretation.



9.4 Aquinas on faith as intellectual assent

- * Doctrine statement. [FACT] Faith is an act of intellect assenting to divine truth under the command of will moved by grace.
- * Argument. [FACT] (1) Revealed truth exceeds demonstrative sight; (2) testimony supplies the object; (3) will commits intellect where evidence is non-coercive; (4) grace orients the person toward divine truth.
- * Presupposition. [CAUTION] Will can responsibly govern assent without making truth arbitrary, and divine testimony is trustworthy.
- * Distinction. [FACT] Faith is not opinion: it has firm assent; it is not knowledge in the strict demonstrative/vision sense: its object is unseen.
- * Canonical example. [FACT] Reason may establish that God exists, while Trinity remains a mystery accepted on revelation.
- * Objection -> reply. [CAUTION] Will-governed belief risks voluntarism. Aquinas replies that motives of credibility and rational preambles make assent reasonable though not demonstrative.



9.5 Kierkegaardian faith and Indian śraddhā (faithful trust)

- Doctrine statement. [FACT] Kierkegaardian faith is passionate commitment amid objective uncertainty; Indian śraddhā (faithful trust)* is disciplined trust that enables inquiry and practice rather than blind credulity.
- Argument. [FACT] Existential relation cannot be replaced by detached proof; commitment shapes the knower. In the Gītā (Song of the Lord)* and Vedāntic pedagogy, trust in teacher/scripture initiates verification through practice and insight.
- * Presupposition. [CAUTION] Transformative truths require participation, not observation alone.
- * Distinction. [FACT] Supra-rational is not irrational: exceeding proof differs from contradicting reason.
- Canonical examples. [FACT] Abraham dramatises Kierkegaard's paradox; śravaṇa–manana–nididhyāśana (hearing scripture, reflective reasoning and deep contemplation)* moves from hearing through reasoning to assimilation.
- * Objection -> reply. [CAUTION] Unchecked commitment can sanctify fanaticism. Reply: authentic faith remains answerable to coherence, ethical fruit and self-critical interpretation.



9.6 Science and religion: the four models (2020 Q5(a) owner-module)

Doctrine statement. [FACT] The standard philosophical map of the science–religion relation is Ian Barbour's fourfold typology (Religion and Science: Historical and Contemporary Issues, 1997; When Science Meets Religion*, 2000): Conflict, Independence, Dialogue, Integration.

* The four models, with their arguments and costs.

1. Conflict. [FACT] Science and religion make competing claims about the same world, so one must yield. Two mirror-image versions: scientific materialism (only what science certifies is real) and biblical/scriptural literalism. The historiographical support is the "warfare thesis" of John William Draper (History of the Conflict between Religion and Science, 1874) and Andrew Dickson White (A History of the Warfare of Science with Theology in Christendom, 1896). [CAUTION] Important discipline: the warfare thesis is now rejected by most historians of science as a polemical nineteenth-century construction; saying so is a mark-earning qualification, not a digression.

2. Independence. [FACT] The two occupy separate domains, ask different questions and use different languages, so they cannot conflict. Stephen Jay Gould's NOMA — Non-Overlapping Magisteria (Rocks of Ages, 1999): science covers the empirical realm of fact and theory, religion the realm of ultimate meaning and moral value. Neo-orthodox theology and Wittgensteinian language-game readings give the same result from different premises. Cost: it purchases peace by forbidding either side to say anything the other could contest, which few believers or scientists accept.

3. Dialogue. [FACT] The domains are distinct but touch at boundary questions — why there is a universe at all, why it is intelligible, why the constants permit life — and at methodological parallels (models, metaphors, paradigms, the theory-ladenness of data in both). Cost: fruitful but non-committal; it establishes conversation, not conclusions.

4. Integration. [FACT] Substantive contact: natural theology (fine-tuning arguments), theology of nature (revising doctrine in the light of evolution and cosmology), and systematic syntheses such as process thought. Cost: hostage to the science of the day; yesterday's integration becomes tomorrow's embarrassment.

[CAUTION] John Haught's parallel typology — Conflict, Contrast, Contact, Confirmation* — is a legitimate alternative to cite, with "Confirmation" adding the claim that religion positively supports the scientific enterprise by underwriting the world's intelligibility.

Indian parity (mandatory for this file). [FACT] The Indian tradition supplies distinctive material rather than a mere echo. Vivekananda presented Vedānta (school grounded in the concluding teaching of the Vedas) as the tradition most able to accept scientific findings because it grounds religion in verifiable experience rather than dogma, and described the disciplines of realisation as a "science of the soul" — a strong claim that must be reported as a claim, not endorsed. Radhakrishnan treats scientific and religious knowing as different levels of one integral experience. Aurobindo's evolutionary metaphysics is an explicit integration model. [CAUTION] The classical pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) framework already contains the epistemological core of the debate: whether śabda (verbal testimony) (testimony) is an independent source of knowledge alongside pratyakṣa (perception) and anumāna (inference)* is exactly the "can revelation add anything?" question in Indian dress — Cārvāka (materialist school) says no, Nyāya (logic and realist epistemology school) and Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school) say yes.

* Presupposition. [CAUTION] That "science" and "religion" name two stable, comparable things — a presupposition that the historicist critique denies, since both categories are modern and internally plural.

Objection -> reply. [CAUTION] Objection: the typology is descriptively neat but normatively empty — it does not tell you which model is correct*. Reply: it is a classification of positions, and the argument must be made model by model; the defensible position is usually a domain-sensitive mixture — independence about method, dialogue about boundary questions, conflict only where a religious claim is genuinely empirical.

* Verdict formula. [CAUTION] "Neither wholesale conflict nor wholesale independence survives scrutiny. Conflict overgeneralises from a few historically distorted episodes; independence saves the peace by silencing both parties. The defensible position is dialogue at the boundary questions with local conflict where an empirical claim is actually made — and that verdict, not a narrative of Galileo, is what the question wants."

↓

9.7 Faith and belief — the distinction, and the tenets of faith (2020 Q7(c) owner-module)

Doctrine statement. [FACT] Belief is propositional assent — believing that p. Faith is a fiducial and volitional relation — believing in*, trusting, entrusting oneself to. Every faith involves beliefs; not every belief involves faith.

* The distinction, in five axes. [CAUTION]

↓

Axis	Belief	Faith
Object	A proposition	A person, reality or ultimate
Grammar	Believe that	Believe in / trust
Mode	Cognitive assent	Assent plus trust, commitment, risk
Voluntariness	Largely involuntary (one cannot decide to believe it is raining)	Involves the will; faith can be given
Failure-mode	Falsehood	Betrayal, infidelity, apostasy
Degrees	Degrees of confidence	Degrees of fidelity and depth

The canonical supports. [FACT] Aquinas' scholastic pair: fides quae creditur (the content that is believed) (the faith which is believed — the content, the creed) and fides qua creditur (the act by which one believes) (the faith by which one believes — the act and disposition). [FACT] Wilfred Cantwell Smith, Faith and Belief (1979): "faith" names a universal, cross-cultural human orientation to transcendence, whereas "belief" in its modern propositional sense is a historically recent narrowing — the word once meant something closer to "hold dear" (by-lieve, cognate with lief). [FACT] Tillich: faith is the state of being grasped by an ultimate concern, which is why idolatry (an ultimate concern in something non-ultimate) is faith's characteristic failure, not unbelief. [FACT] Buber: the I–Thou relation cannot be reduced to I–It* propositions.

* The "basic tenets of faith" (the printed stem asks for these — enumerate them). [CAUTION] (1) an object held to be ultimate; (2) assent to some

content about it; (3) trust exceeding the available evidence; (4) commitment of the will, with consequent risk; (5) hope oriented to a future not yet secured; (6) a community and tradition that transmits and disciplines it; (7) fruits — a transformed pattern of life by which it is tested.

Indian parity. [FACT] Śraddhā (faithful trust) is precisely the faith-side rather than the belief-side: the Gītā (Song of the Lord) 17.2–3 grades śraddhā as sāttvika (clarity-dominated), rājasa (passion-dominated) or tāmasa (inertia-dominated) and states that a person is constituted by their śraddhā — "as is one's śraddhā, so is one". [FACT] In Advaita (non-dual Vedānta) pedagogy śraddhā is one of the six inner accomplishments and functions as the trust that makes inquiry possible, to be replaced by realisation, not preserved as belief. [FACT] Buddhism's saddhā (provisional trust directed toward verification) is explicitly provisional and verification-directed — the Kālāma Sutta (Discourse to the Kālāmas) (AN 3.65) counsels not to accept a teaching merely on report, lineage, scripture, logic or the teacher's authority, but to test it in experience. [CAUTION] This gives Indian material a genuine advantage on this question: śraddhā/saddhā is trust that initiates verification, whereas Western "faith" often has to defend itself as trust that replaces* verification.

Objection -> reply. [CAUTION] Objection: the distinction is verbal; "believing in" reduces to "believing that a certain being exists and is trustworthy". Reply: the reduction loses the performative and relational element — one can believe that a person is reliable while refusing to entrust anything to them; faith is constituted by the entrusting. [CAUTION] Second objection: if faith is volitional it is doxastically irresponsible. Reply: the will operates where evidence is genuinely non-coercive, which is the only case in dispute (Aquinas; James's "genuine option" in The Will to Believe*). Verdict formula. [CAUTION] "Faith is not a weaker belief; it is a different act. Belief is the cognitive component within* faith, and the two can come apart in both directions — orthodox belief without trust, and trust that outruns any belief its holder can articulate."

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9.8 Miracles: Hume's argument and its critics

Doctrine statement. [FACT] Hume, An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding, Section X, "Of Miracles" (1748), defines a miracle as "a violation of the laws of nature"* brought about by a particular volition of the Deity, and argues that testimony can never establish one.

***Argument (Part I — the a priori balance). [FACT] (1) A wise man proportions his belief to the evidence. (2) The laws of nature are supported by uniform, exceptionless experience — the strongest empirical evidence there is. (3) Testimony is supported by experience of human reliability, which is strong but not uniform. (4) A miracle report therefore sets uniform experience against non-uniform experience, and the weaker must yield. (5) Hume's maxim:** no testimony suffices to establish a miracle unless its falsehood would be more miraculous than the fact it endeavours to establish — and even then one subtracts the lesser marvel from the greater.

***Argument (Part II — the four a posteriori considerations). [FACT] (a) No miracle is attested by a sufficient number of witnesses of unquestioned good sense, education, integrity and public reputation with much to lose. (b) Human nature has a standing passion for surprise and wonder, which multiplies marvellous reports. (c) Miracle reports flourish chiefly among ignorant and barbarous nations, or descend from such origins. (d) Contrary miracles cancel:** since the miracles of rival religions support incompatible systems, each set of testimonies destroys the credit of the others.

* Replies, with their force. [CAUTION]

* The definitional reply: if "law of nature" means an exceptionless regularity, a genuine exception simply shows the supposed law was mis-stated — so miracles are defined out of existence rather than disproved. Richard Swinburne therefore recasts a miracle as a non-repeatable counter-instance to a law that remains otherwise well-confirmed.

The evidential reply (Swinburne): the principles of credulity and testimony give apparent memory, perception and report a prima facie* right to be believed; Hume's rule effectively makes them powerless in exactly the case where they might matter, which is question-begging.

* **The Bayesian reply (John Earman, Hume's Abject Failure, 2000):** Hume's argument confuses the prior improbability of an event with the posterior probability given testimony; multiple independent witnesses of moderate reliability can raise the posterior probability of a very improbable event arbitrarily high.

* The circularity charge (C. S. Lewis and others): to know that uniform experience is against miracles, one must already know that all miracle reports are false — which is the conclusion.

The contrary-miracles reply: the cancellation argument assumes rival traditions' miracles support mutually exclusive* total systems; if traditions overlap in what their miracles are taken to attest, cancellation is not automatic.

[CAUTION] What survives: Hume's Part II is a permanently useful checklist of evidential caution*; his Part I is now widely regarded as too strong, since it would exclude testimony for any sufficiently improbable event, including well-attested scientific anomalies.

Indian parity. [FACT] The tradition is markedly unenthusiastic about the evidential use of the marvellous. Patañjali's Yoga-sūtra (Aphorisms on Yoga) Book III catalogues the siddhis (extraordinary yogic powers)/vibhūtis (extraordinary yogic accomplishments) in detail and then (3.37) declares them obstacles to samādhi (meditative absorption) though "accomplishments" in the outward-turned state — the powers are real but soteriologically worthless. [FACT] Buddhism records iddhi (psychic power) while the Kevaddha Sutta (Discourse to Kevaddha) (DN 11) has the Buddha reject the display of psychic powers as a means of gaining converts, preferring the "miracle of instruction". [FACT] Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school) grounds Vedic authority in apauruṣeya (authorless and not of human origin) eternality precisely so that it needs no miraculous authentication. [CAUTION] Hence, where Western apologetics uses miracles to authenticate revelation, Indian systems mostly decline* the strategy — a genuine comparative point rather than a parallel.

* Verdict formula. [CAUTION] "Hume shows that miracle-testimony faces an unusually heavy evidential burden; he does not show that the burden is in principle unmeetable. The stronger conclusion is that a miracle can at best be evidence for those already inside an interpretive framework that identifies which events would count as divine action — which returns the question to revelation and faith."

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9.9 Evidentialism and Reformed epistemology (2023 Q5(b) owner-module)

* The question. [FACT] "Can religious beliefs be justified?" is not the question whether God exists; it is the question of what standard a religious belief must meet to be rationally held.

Evidentialism. [FACT] Thesis: a belief is rational only if it is proportioned to the evidence, and religious belief must meet the same standard as any other. John Locke ties assent to the probability of the evidence; W. K. Clifford ("The Ethics of Belief", 1877) makes it a moral matter — "it is wrong always, everywhere, and for anyone, to believe anything upon insufficient evidence", illustrated by the shipowner who sends an unseaworthy ship to sea on unexamined hope. [FACT] Antony Flew's presumption of atheism: the burden of proof lies on the affirmative claim, and in the absence of sufficient evidence the rational default is not agnosticism but not-believing*.

* **Reply (William James, The Will to Believe, 1896): where an option is living, forced and momentous**, and the evidence is genuinely inconclusive, our "passional nature" may lawfully decide; Clifford's rule is itself a passional preference for avoiding error over gaining truth. [CAUTION] James's argument is limited to genuinely undecidable options and does not license belief against evidence.

* Reformed epistemology. [FACT] **Thesis (Alvin Plantinga, "Reason and Belief in God", 1983; Warranted Christian Belief, 2000): belief in God can be properly basic** — rationally held without being inferred from other beliefs.

* Argument: (1) The evidentialist objection presupposes classical foundationalism: a belief is rational only if self-evident, incorrigible, evident to the senses, or inferred from such. (2) That criterion is self-referentially incoherent — it is itself none of those things and is not derivable from them. (3) It is also too narrow: memory beliefs, beliefs in other minds and beliefs about the past are not derived from that base but are plainly rational. (4) So basicity is not confined to the classical foundationalist's list. (5) Belief in God, formed in appropriate circumstances (gratitude, guilt, wonder, reading scripture), is basic in the same way — grounded in experience without being inferred.

Warrant and proper function: for Plantinga, warrant is what turns true belief into knowledge — a belief has warrant when produced by cognitive faculties functioning properly, in an appropriate environment, according to a design plan aimed at truth. If Calvin's sensus divinitatis (innate sense of the divine) exists and works properly, theistic belief has warrant without argument. Note the structure: this shows that if theism is true, theistic belief is very likely warranted — so there is no viable de jure objection independent of the de facto* question.

* The Great Pumpkin objection: if belief in God can be properly basic, so can belief in anything at all. Reply: basicity is not arbitrariness — properly basic beliefs are grounded in circumstances, are defeasible, and belong to a community's disciplined doxastic practice; there is no analogous faculty or ground for the Great Pumpkin. [CAUTION] Critics respond that this makes the criterion community-relative, which readmits the Son-of-Great-Pumpkin problem for well-established rival traditions.

[FACT] William Alston's complementary route (Perceiving God*, 1991): our engagement in doxastic practices — including sense perception — cannot be shown reliable without circularity; since we nonetheless rationally engage in them, socially established religious practice is in the same epistemic boat, and it is practically rational to engage in it absent sufficient reason to think it unreliable. Route to Religious Experience §9.8.

Indian parity. [FACT] The whole dispute maps onto the pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) debate. Cārvāka (materialist school) is the strict evidentialist — only pratyakṣa (perception), so no supersensible belief is justified. Nyāya (logic and realist epistemology school) is the inferentialist — anumāna (inference) and āpta-vākya (statement of a trustworthy speaker)* justify. **Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school)'s svataḥ-prāmāṇya (intrinsic validity of cognition) (intrinsic validity: a cognition is valid on its own until defeated) is the closest classical analogue of Reformed epistemology's proper basicity, and Nyāya's *parataḥ-prāmāṇya (validity established through external confirmation)*** (extrinsic validity: validity must be established by something further) is the closest analogue of evidentialism. [CAUTION] This mapping is the single most valuable move available in this question, because it converts a Western epistemology debate into an Indian one without distortion.

* Objection -> reply. [CAUTION] Objection: properly basic religious belief is immune to criticism. Reply: Plantinga insists it is defeasible — the problem of evil, projection theories and cognitive-science explanations are all potential defeaters that must be met. [CAUTION] Second objection: religious diversity means incompatible beliefs are all "properly basic". Reply: diversity is a defeater to be answered, not an automatic refutation — but no one holds it is easily answered.

* Verdict formula. [CAUTION] "Religious beliefs can be justified, but not in the way natural theology once hoped. The evidentialist standard, taken strictly, disqualifies far more than religion; the Reformed alternative rescues rationality at the cost of making it internal to a doxastic practice — and then religious diversity, not evidential insufficiency, becomes the real problem."

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10. INTER-THINKER / INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES

Position	Reason	Revelation	Faith	Main risk
Rationalism/evidentialism	[FACT] Judge of belief	Must be evidenced	Proportioned to evidence	Reduction of commitment
Aquinas	[FACT] Preambles and coherence	Mysteries beyond reason	Firm intellectual assent	Two-tier tension
Fideism	[CAUTION] Limited or irrelevant	Authoritative	Primary leap/trust	Arbitrariness
Hick	[FACT] Interprets experience critically	Event/self-disclosure	Experiencing-as	Projection
Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school)	[FACT] Interprets injunction/testimony	Apauruṣeya (authorless and not of human origin) Veda, not creator speech	Trust in Vedic authority	Cross-tradition warrant
Advaita (non-dual Vedānta)	[FACT] Manana (reflective reasoning) removes doubt	Śruti (revealed Vedic scripture) discloses Brahman (ultimate reality)	Śraddhā (faithful trust) enables inquiry	Scriptural circularity
Evidentialism (Locke, Clifford, Flew)	[FACT] Sole arbiter; proportion assent to evidence	Must be independently evidenced	Rational only if evidenced	Self-application; over-strict criterion
Reformed epistemology (Plantinga)	[CAUTION] Not the sole arbiter	May be received basically	Properly basic, warranted, defeasible	Religious diversity as a defeater
Alston	[FACT] Critical, non-foundationalist	Mediated in practice	Rational participation in a doxastic practice	Circularity shared with sense perception
Barbour's typology	[FACT] Model-dependent	Model-dependent	Model-dependent	Descriptive, not normative

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11. CRITICISMS AND REPLIES

- Evidential challenge. [CAUTION] Cliffordian ethics of belief rejects assent without sufficient evidence. Reply: testimony, cumulative evidence and practical commitment can be rational without demonstration.
- Competing revelation. [CAUTION] Rival scriptures cannot all be literally infallible in incompatible claims. Reply: distinguish core disclosure from historically conditioned interpretation; critics call this revisionary.
- Circularity. [CAUTION] Scripture authenticated by the community and community by scripture. Reply: many epistemic practices use reciprocal support; the issue is whether the circle is vicious or a coherent web.
- Fideist immunity. [CAUTION] Faith insulated from criticism licenses fanaticism. Reply: faith may transcend proof while remaining constrained by non-contradiction and ethical fruits.

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12. COMMON UPSC TRAPS

1. [CAUTION] Do not define faith as belief without evidence; distinguish trust, assent and commitment.
2. [CAUTION] Do not say Aquinas lets faith contradict reason.
3. [CAUTION] Do not conflate revelation with scripture or inspiration.
4. [CAUTION] Do not call Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school)'s Veda revelation from a personal God.
5. [CAUTION] The common Latin slogan associated with believing "because absurd" should not be quoted as Tertullian's exact wording without qualification.
6. [CAUTION] In "faith indispensable for revelation," distinguish objective disclosure from subjective reception.
7. [CAUTION] Do not narrate Galileo and call it the science–religion question. Use Barbour's four models (conflict/independence/dialogue/integration) and note that the Draper–White "warfare thesis" is rejected by most historians of science.
8. [CAUTION] Do not treat NOMA as the obvious solution. Independence buys peace by forbidding both sides to make claims the other could contest — state that cost.
9. [CAUTION] Do not define faith as "belief without evidence" and then distinguish it from belief. The distinction is trust/entrusting vs propositional assent; use fides qua (act of trusting faith)/fides quae (content of faith) and Gītā (Song of the Lord) 17.2–3 on śraddhā (faithful trust).
10. [CAUTION] Do not attribute to Hume the claim that miracles are impossible. His claim is about the evidential force of testimony; and his definition of a miracle as a violation of natural law is itself contested (Swinburne's non-repeatable counter-instance).
11. [CAUTION] Do not present Clifford's maxim without James's reply, or James's reply without its restriction to living, forced and momentous options where evidence is genuinely inconclusive.
12. [CAUTION] Do not say Plantinga claims God's existence is self-evident. He claims theistic belief can be properly basic — grounded, warranted and defeasible — and that classical foundationalism is self-referentially incoherent.
13. [CAUTION] When comparing, use the exact Indian analogues: Mīmāṃsā's svataḥ-prāmāṇya (intrinsic validity of cognition) ≈ proper basicity; Nyāya (logic and realist epistemology school)'s parataḥ-prāmāṇya (validity established through external confirmation) ≈ evidentialism. Do not assert a looser parallel.

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13. KEYWORD & STATEMENT BANK

Keywords: [FACT] natural theology · revealed theology · preambles of faith · mystery · propositional/non-propositional revelation · testimony · inspiration · apauruṣeya (authorless and not of human origin) · śabda (verbal testimony) · pratyakṣa (perception)/anumāna (inference) · svataḥ-prāmāṇya (intrinsic validity of cognition)/parataḥ-prāmāṇya (validity established through external confirmation) · intellectual assent · fides qua (act of trusting faith)/fides quae (content of faith) · will · grace · motives of credibility · evidentialism · ethics of belief · presumption of atheism · living/forced/momentous option · Reformed epistemology · properly basic belief · classical foundationalism · warrant · proper function · sensus divinitatis (innate sense of the divine) · Great Pumpkin objection · doxastic practice · defeater · fideism · objective uncertainty · experiencing-as · ultimate concern · śraddhā (faithful trust) · saddhā (provisional trust directed toward verification) · śravaṇa (hearing scriptural teaching) · manana (reflective reasoning) · nididhyāsana (deep contemplative assimilation) · conflict/independence/dialogue/integration · NOMA · warfare thesis · boundary questions · miracle · violation of a law of nature · non-repeatable counter-instance · principle of credulity · siddhi (extraordinary yogic power)/vibhūti (extraordinary yogic accomplishment).

Safe formulations: [CAUTION] "Faith may go beyond coercive proof without going against reason." · "Revelation requires both an alleged disclosure and a warranted mode of reception." · "Faith is not a weaker belief; it is a different act, of which belief is one component." · "Hume raised the evidential bar for miracles; he did not show it unclearable." · "The evidentialist standard, applied strictly, disqualifies far more than religion."

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CORPUS-DRIVEN DEPTH DELTA (expanded PYQ audit)

- * [CAUTION] Priority: Primary ownership is 11 of 112 parts; 2018 has no owned part, while 2020–2025 broaden the clause beyond a simple reason-versus-faith binary.
- * [FACT] Required doctrinal depth: Required depth includes self-revelation, religion under scientific-technological modernity, faith versus belief, reason as regulative, and the epistemic warrant of revelation.
- * ☐ Trap / answer consequence: Do not equate revelation with private feeling or faith with evidence-free belief; separate propositional, personal/event and experiential models.

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14. PYQ ROUTING (2018–2025)

[CAUTION] Corpus signal: 11 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper II corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

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Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2019	Q5(a)	10 marks	What is instrumental to self-revelation: Faith or Reason? Justify your position.
2020	Q5(a)	10 marks	Discuss the significance of 'Religion' vis-à-vis the present scientific and technological development.
2020	Q7(c)	15 marks	What are the basic tenets of faith? Distinguish between faith and belief.
2021	Q7(a)	20 marks	Discuss the role of reason and faith in religion. Can reason be a regulative force in the formulation of religious beliefs? Explain.
2022	Q5(d)	10 marks	Is the notion of faith indispensable for the idea of revelation? Critically comment.
2023	Q5(b)	10 marks	Can religious beliefs be justified? Discuss.
2023	Q6(c)	15 marks	Explain the rational and irrational aspects of faith in the discourse of religion.
2024	Q5(d)	10 marks	Discuss the role of reason in religion.
2024	Q7(b)	15 marks	What kind of epistemic justifications are possible with regard to claims to revelation? Discuss with your own comments.
2025	Q5(e)	10 marks	How does Aquinas' account of Faith as "an intellectual assent" reconcile the juxtaposition between Reason and Faith? Discuss.
2025	Q6(c)	15 marks	Distinguish between Natural Theology and Revealed Theology in the context of the Propositional view of Revelation.

See the Philosophy of Religion PYQ Bank, 2018–2025.

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15. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE (10 / 15 / 20 MARKS)

10 marks

Define reason/revelation/faith term asked -> doctrine's internal relation -> one distinction -> one objection -> direct verdict.

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15 marks

Frame warrant problem -> propositional or encounter model in steps -> criteria of justification -> rival model/Indian comparison -> objection and reply.

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20 marks

Map the three concepts -> strongest harmony and conflict models -> presuppositions -> competing-revelation/evidential objections -> Indian–Western comparison -> defended synthesis.

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16. DIRECTIVE DECODER

Directive	Examiner is buying	Structural consequence	Live example
What is instrumental to X: A or B? Justify your position	A choice, defended — not "both are important"	Choose, give the strongest case, then concede what the loser explains better	2019 Q5(a) faith or reason for self-revelation
Discuss the significance of X vis-à-vis Y	A relation, modelled	Use a typology (Barbour) rather than a narrative	2020 Q5(a)
What are the basic tenets of X? Distinguish X and Y	Two separate deliverables	Enumerate the tenets; then a differentia table	2020 Q7(c)
Can A be a regulative force in B? Explain	The precise sense of "regulative"	Regulative (constrains, vetoes, disciplines) ≠ constitutive (generates content)	2021 Q7(a)
Critically comment	A short but evaluative verdict (10m)	No survey; one distinction, one objection, one verdict	2022 Q5(d)
Can X be justified? Discuss	The standard of justification, not the truth of X	Name the epistemology first (evidentialist? basic?)	2023 Q5(b)
Explain the rational and irrational aspects of X	Three categories, not two	Rational / supra-rational / irrational — the middle term is the answer	2023 Q6(c)
What kind of epistemic justifications are possible... with your own comments	A typology plus a first-person assessment	List criteria (coherence, testimony, fruits, transformation), then rank them yourself	2024 Q7(b)
How does X reconcile A and B?	The mechanism of reconciliation, stated as a structure	Name the two storeys and the hinge between them	2025 Q5(e) Aquinas
Distinguish A and B in the context of C	A three-term answer; C is not decorative	Natural vs revealed theology as seen from the propositional model	2025 Q6(c)

[MEMORY] Rule: this clause punishes binaries. Reason/faith, rational/irrational, science/religion and evidence/basicality are all three-term distinctions once you add the middle category (supra-rational, dialogue, defeasible basicality).

17. GRADED VERDICT LADDER

Band	What the script contains	Typical fault
Weak (≈40%)	"Reason argues, faith trusts"; Aquinas and Kierkegaard named	No epistemology; faith defined as evidence-free belief
Average (≈50%)	The four stances; propositional/non-propositional revelation	Indian material limited to one sentence on śraddhā (faithful trust)
Good (≈60%)	One position reconstructed with premises; one objection answered	Middle category (supra-rational / dialogue / defeasible basicality) missing
Strong (≈65–70%)	Justification standard named; Indian pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) parity used; competing-revelation problem raised	Verdict summarises rather than decides
Top (≈70%+)	All the above + a discriminating distinction (fides qua (act of trusting faith)/quae; svataḥ (intrinsically or from itself)/parataḥ-prāmāṇya (validity established through external confirmation); regulative vs constitutive; violation vs non-repeatable counter-instance) + a statement of the defeater that would change the verdict	—

Graded-verdict templates:

[CAUTION] Reason/faith stem:* "Reason is regulative but not constitutive of religious belief: it can veto incoherence, discipline interpretation and assess evidence, but it does not generate the content that faith receives."
[CAUTION] Justification stem: "Religious beliefs can be justified, but the standard cannot be the strict evidentialist one, which disqualifies memory and other minds as well. Once justification is located inside a doxastic practice, the live objection changes from insufficient evidence to incompatible

practices*."
[CAUTION] Revelation stem:* "A revelation-claim is warranted, if at all, by a convergence — internal coherence, moral fruits, the recipient's experience, communal transmission and congruence with reason — no one of which is decisive, and none of which is neutral between traditions."

18. FACTUAL AND QUOTATION DISCIPLINE

Item	Status	Safe use
Credo ut intelligam	[FACT] Anselmian formula (Proslogion 1, in the "faith seeking understanding" tradition from Augustine)	Attribute to the Augustinian–Anselmian tradition
Credo quia absurdum	[VERIFY] Not a verified verbatim Tertullian sentence	Call it "a later slogan for extreme fideism"
Aquinas on faith as a mean between knowledge and opinion	[FACT] ST II-II q.1–q.4	Paraphrase; do not fabricate English quotation
Clifford's maxim	[FACT] W. K. Clifford, "The Ethics of Belief" (1877)	The shipowner example is his
The Will to Believe	[FACT] William James (1896)	The reply is restricted to living, forced, momentous options
"Of Miracles"	[FACT] Hume, Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding, Section X	Part I = the maxim; Part II = the four considerations
Non-repeatable counter-instance	[FACT] Richard Swinburne's recasting of "miracle"	Use to show Hume's definition is contestable
Hume's Abject Failure	[FACT] John Earman (2000)	The Bayesian critique
Draper–White "warfare thesis"	[FACT] Real books (1874, 1896)	[CAUTION] Now rejected by most historians of science — say so
NOMA	[FACT] Stephen Jay Gould, Rocks of Ages (1999)	Independence model
Fourfold typology	[FACT] Ian Barbour	Haught's Conflict/Contrast/Contact/Confirmation is the alternative
Faith and Belief	[FACT] Wilfred Cantwell Smith (1979)	For the historical narrowing of "belief"
"Reason and Belief in God" / Warranted Christian Belief	[FACT] Alvin Plantinga (1983; 2000)	Proper basicity, warrant, proper function, sensus divinitatis (innate sense of the divine)
Perceiving God	[FACT] William Alston (1991)	Doxastic practices
Gītā (Song of the Lord) 17.2–3 on śraddhā (faithful trust)	[FACT] Verified chapter/verse	"As is one's śraddhā (faithful trust), so is one" — paraphrase
Kālāma Sutta (Discourse to the Kālāmas) (AN 3.65), Kevaddha Sutta (Discourse to Kevaddha) (DN 11)	[FACT] Verified nikāya (collection of Buddhist discourses) references	Paraphrase; do not quote a translation as canonical
Yoga-sūtra (Aphorisms on Yoga) 3.37 on siddhis (extraordinary yogic powers) as obstacles	[FACT] Verified sūtra (aphoristic teaching)	The key Indian anti-miracle datum

19. LINK-OUTS

* Proofs for God — what reason can and cannot establish unaided

* Religious Experience — Alston’s doxastic practice; experience as a ground of warrant

* Religious Language — verification, falsification and the meaning of religious claims

* Religious Pluralism — competing revelations and the diversity defeater

* Religion without God — Cārvāka (materialist school)’s strict evidentialism; Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school)’s authorless authority

Paper I: Mīmāṃsā.md) — apauruṣeya (authorless and not of human origin), svataḥ-prāmāṇya (intrinsic validity of cognition)*

Paper I: Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika (logic and particularist realist schools).md) — śabda (verbal testimony) as pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge), parataḥ-prāmāṇya (validity established through external confirmation)*

* Paper I: Cārvāka.md) — the limit case of evidentialism

* Paper I: Existentialism — Kierkegaard’s leap

* Paper I: Kant — the limits of speculative reason

* Philosophy of Religion PYQ Bank, 2018–2025

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SOURCES

Thomas Aquinas, Summa Theologiae*, II-II qq.1–7 (faith).

Søren Kierkegaard, Concluding Unscientific Postscript and Fear and Trembling*.

David Hume, An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding, Section X; John Earman, Hume’s Abject Failure*.

W. K. Clifford, "The Ethics of Belief"; William James, The Will to Believe*.

Alvin Plantinga, "Reason and Belief in God" and Warranted Christian Belief; William Alston, Perceiving God*.

Ian Barbour, Religion and Science; Stephen Jay Gould, Rocks of Ages; John Haught, Science and Religion*.

Wilfred Cantwell Smith, Faith and Belief; Paul Tillich, Dynamics of Faith*.

John Hick, Philosophy of Religion*.

* Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school), Nyāya (logic and realist epistemology school) and Vedānta (school grounded in the concluding teaching of the Vedas) discussions in S. C. Chatterjee & D. M. Datta and C. D. Sharma.

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CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

A. Three-term control

* Reason: argument, coherence, evidence, interpretation and criticism.

* Revelation: alleged divine self-disclosure through proposition, event or encounter.

* Faith: assent plus trust, commitment, hope and fidelity.

* Formula: reason regulates; revelation discloses; faith receives.

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B. Four relation models

Model	Thinker	Core claim	Cost
Rationalism	Locke, Clifford	reason judges every religious claim	can reduce lived commitment
Fideism	Kierkegaard as qualified case	faith transcends proof	arbitrariness if insulated
Faith seeking understanding	Augustine, Anselm	faith initiates rational inquiry	starts within commitment
Two-source harmony	Aquinas	preambles by reason, mysteries by revelation	credibility of revelation remains

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C. Revelation distinctions

* Propositional: divinely authorised truths; doctrine articulates content.

* Non-propositional: divine action or presence encountered and interpreted.

* Revelation is not identical with scripture, inspiration or infallibility.

* Objective disclosure and subjective reception must be separated.

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D. Aquinas answer spine

1. Faith is an act of intellect.
2. The intellect assents to divine truth.
3. The will commands assent and grace moves the person.
4. Faith is firm like knowledge but lacks demonstrative vision.
5. Reason proves preambles; revelation supplies mysteries.
6. Both derive from God and therefore cannot genuinely contradict.

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E. Kierkegaard and supra-rational faith

* Objective uncertainty creates the field for passionate appropriation.

* Leap means existential commitment, not permission to believe contradictions.

* Supra-rational exceeds proof; irrational violates coherence or evidence.

* Abraham is an existential test, not a general licence for fanaticism.

↓

F. Faith versus belief

Belief	Faith
believes that	believes in / trusts
proposition	person or ultimate
cognitive assent	assent plus entrusting
mainly truth/falsity	fidelity/betrayal
may remain detached	reshapes action and identity

↓

Use fides quae (content of faith) for content and fides qua (act of trusting faith) for the believing disposition.

↓

G. Science and religion

* Barbour: Conflict, Independence, Dialogue, Integration.

* Warfare thesis: historically overgeneralised.

* NOMA: peace at the cost of mutual silence.

* Best verdict: dialogue at boundary questions, local conflict on empirical claims.

* Technology answers what can be done; ethics and religion contest what ought to be done.

↓

H. Miracles and testimony

* Hume: uniform experience outweighs fallible testimony; rival miracle claims cancel.

* Surviving insight: unusually high evidential burden and witness-quality tests.

* Critiques: contested definition, Bayesian updating, independent testimony, circularity.

Indian contrast: siddhis (extraordinary yogic powers)* and displays are often treated as distractions, not authentication.

↓

I. Justification debate

* Evidentialism: proportion belief to evidence; Clifford and Flew.

* James: living, forced, momentous options under genuine evidential indecision.

* Plantinga: properly basic, grounded, warranted and defeasible belief.

* Great Pumpkin: basicality is constrained by grounds, functioning and defeaters.

* Alston: socially established doxastic practices cannot be validated non-circularly.

↓

J. Indian parity

Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school) svataḥ-prāmāṇya (intrinsic validity of cognition)*: cognition valid until defeated.
Nyāya (logic and realist epistemology school) parataḥ-prāmāṇya (validity established through external confirmation)*: validity established through further certification.
Śabda (verbal testimony) can be an independent pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge)* without creator-dictation.
Advaita (non-dual Vedānta): śravaṇa–manana–nididhyāsana (hearing scripture, reflective reasoning and deep contemplation)*; reason removes doubt after disclosure.
Buddhist saddhā (provisional trust directed toward verification)*: provisional trust directed toward verification.



K. Eleven PYQ routes

2019 self-revelation: choose faith for reception, reason for regulation.
2020 science: Barbour, then normative relevance.
2020 faith/belief: seven tenets plus five axes.
2021 regulative reason: regulative is not constitutive.
2022 revelation: objective disclosure versus subjective reception.
2023 justification: evidentialism versus proper basicity.
2023 rational/irrational: add the supra-rational middle.
2024 reason: natural theology, coherence, interpretation and limits.
2024 revelation warrant: convergent, defeasible criteria.
2025 Aquinas: intellect, will, grace, preambles and mysteries.
2025 natural/revealed theology: distinguish them inside the propositional model.



L. Final answer discipline

1. Define the exact disputed term.
2. State whether the question concerns source, reception, warrant or commitment.
3. Reconstruct one named position.
4. Add the strongest objection and reply.
5. Use one precise Indian comparison.
6. End with a graded verdict, not "both are important".

Final judgement: Rational religion is neither proof without trust nor trust without criticism. Faith may go beyond coercive proof, but it forfeits philosophical legitimacy when it claims a right to go against reason.



FINAL FLOWCHART ROUTE

Definition and scope -> doctrine and arguments -> objections and replies -> comparisons -> traps -> PYQ demand -> answer architecture -> graded verdict.



FINAL SYNTHESIS BOARD

Ten-stage navigation matrix

Stage	Source-owned unit	Answer move
1	Separate reason, revelation and faith	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict
2	Compare rationalism, fideism, harmony and two-source models	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict
3	Distinguish propositional from non-propositional revelation	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict
4	Explain Aquinas' intellectual assent and Kierkegaard's leap	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict
5	Distinguish faith from belief and map Indian śraddhā (faithful trust)	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict
6	Use Barbour's science–religion models	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict
7	Evaluate Hume on miracles and testimony	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict
8	Compare evidentialism with proper basicity	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict
9	Apply Indian pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) parity	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict
10	Convert doctrine into 10/15/20-mark answers	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict



11-question launchpad

- * PYQ 1 — 2019, Q5(a), 10 marks
- * PYQ 2 — 2020, Q5(a), 10 marks
- * PYQ 3 — 2020, Q7(c), 15 marks
- * PYQ 4 — 2021, Q7(a), 20 marks
- * PYQ 5 — 2022, Q5(d), 10 marks
- * PYQ 6 — 2023, Q5(b), 10 marks
- * PYQ 7 — 2023, Q6(c), 15 marks
- * PYQ 8 — 2024, Q5(d), 10 marks
- * PYQ 9 — 2024, Q7(b), 15 marks
- * PYQ 10 — 2025, Q5(e), 10 marks
- * PYQ 11 — 2025, Q6(c), 15 marks



Mark-wise answer architecture

- * 10 marks: define the exact term; state the doctrinal verdict; reconstruct one named position; add one objection and reply; conclude directly.
- * 15 marks: satisfy every demand; compare on a fixed axis; add source or thinker support; evaluate; end with a graded verdict.
- * 20 marks: frame the problem; reconstruct rival models; use Indian-Western parity where relevant; test assumptions; weigh objections and replies; finish with a qualified conclusion.



1. 0. ONE-SCREEN MAP ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	Reason tests coherence and warrant, revelation claims divine self-disclosure, and faith receives that disclosure through trust and commitment.
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	Each faculty corrects the excess of the others: reason restrains arbitrariness, revelation resists reductionism, and faith converts alleged disclosure into lived commitment.
FINAL VERDICT	Reason is best treated as regulative without being assumed to be the sole source of religious truth.

2. 2. REVELATION ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	Revelation is an alleged divine self-disclosure that supplies truth or presence unavailable to unaided reason.
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	Propositional models emphasise revealed truths, whereas non-propositional models emphasise divine acts or presence interpreted through human experience.
FINAL VERDICT	A revelation claim becomes philosophically credible only when disclosure, interpretation and public criteria are kept distinct.

3. 3. FAITH ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	Faith is firm trust and commitment that goes beyond conclusive proof without necessarily opposing reason.
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	Aquinas explains faith as intellectual assent commanded by the will, while Kierkegaard stresses passionate commitment under objective uncertainty.
FINAL VERDICT	Faith is rationally responsible when it transcends evidence without violating coherence or ignoring defeaters.

4. 4. THE FOUR STANCES — comparison ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	The reason-faith debate concerns whether evidence, trust or distinct sources should govern religious assent.
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	Rationalism risks reducing faith to proof, fideism risks arbitrariness, while harmony and two-source theories preserve rational scrutiny without collapsing mystery into demonstration.
FINAL VERDICT	Aquinas offers the most balanced model when reason establishes preambles and faith assents to mysteries that exceed but do not contradict reason.

5. 6A. INDIAN–WESTERN PARITY BENCH ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	Indian epistemology reframes reason and revelation through pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge), especially śabda (verbal testimony).
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	Mīmāṃsā (Vedic exegesis) defends authorless scripture and intrinsic validity, while Nyāya (logic and realist epistemology) requires externally confirmed credibility.
FINAL VERDICT	The Indian comparison deepens the debate by separating the source of testimony from the conditions of its validity.

6. 9.6 Science and religion: the four models (2020 Q5(a) owner-module) ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	Science explains empirically testable processes, while religion addresses ultimate meaning, value and, at times, claims that intersect with evidence.
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	Conflict and complete independence are too crude; dialogue and qualified integration are stronger where boundary questions arise, but empirical claims remain answerable to evidence.
FINAL VERDICT	The defensible relation is critical dialogue with local conflict, not permanent warfare or effortless harmony.

7. 9.7 Faith and belief — the distinction, and the tenets of faith (2020 Q7(c) owner-module) ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	Belief ordinarily assents to a proposition, whereas faith entrusts the person to an ultimate object and reshapes conduct.
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	The reduction of faith to weak belief misses its volitional, relational and performative dimensions, though faith still includes beliefs that remain open to criticism.
FINAL VERDICT	Faith and belief overlap, but faith is not merely a lower degree of evidential certainty.

8. 9.8 Miracles: Hume's argument and its critics ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	A miracle is an event interpreted as an extraordinary act of divine agency that exceeds the normal course of nature.
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	Hume rightly raises the evidential burden on testimony, but his argument becomes circular if 'miracle' is defined as maximally improbable before the evidence is assessed.
FINAL VERDICT	Miracle testimony can be rationally considered, but only under unusually strict tests of independence, credibility and alternative explanation.

9. 9.9 Evidentialism and Reformed epistemology (2023 Q5(b) owner-module) ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	The justification debate asks whether religious belief requires inferential evidence or may be properly basic yet defeasible.
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	Evidentialism protects responsibility but can impose an unduly narrow foundation; Reformed epistemology widens rational basicity but must answer arbitrariness and religious diversity.
FINAL VERDICT	Religious belief may be non-inferentially justified, but it remains vulnerable to defeaters and comparative criticism.

10. 15. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE (10 / 15 / 20 MARKS) ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	A reason-revelation-faith answer should first identify whether the stem concerns source, reception, warrant or commitment.
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	Marks rise when one named theory is reconstructed, tested by its strongest objection and compared on one precise Indian-Western axis.
FINAL VERDICT	The best conclusion is graded: faith may exceed coercive proof, but it cannot claim immunity from coherence, evidence and moral criticism.